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Roshni Nadar Malhotra was working as a producer with Sky News in London after completing her undergrad in film and television when her father—Shiv Nadar, the founder of HCL Technologies, India's third-largest IT firm—told her to do “something normal.”

“We laughed about it. I asked what is normal?” she tells *Business Today*.

Shiv Nadar, a self-made billionaire who had never been to a B-School himself, advised her to join one. That changed the course of Malhotra's career. After MBA from Kellogg School of Management, she joined the HCL Group in 2008. In 2013, she got inducted on the board of HCLTech, becoming the Chairperson in 2020. She is ranked second on *BT*'s Most Powerful Women in Business list. Earlier this year, she was declared the richest woman in India by the *M3M Hurun India Rich List*.

Joining HCLTech was a great decision for her, she says. “When you are pivoting in your career—we have all had these experiences in our lives—sometimes it can help to get a bit of training and education in the middle,” she says. An outsider to the IT industry, Malhotra says the biggest challenge she faced was not as a woman but as a young person. As Chair, Malhotra has made sure that 50% of HCLTech's board comprises women. Edited excerpts from an interview:

Q: Did you always envision yourself in a leadership role or did it evolve over time?

A: If you've looked at [my father's] journey, he founded HCL Group in 1976, and initially it used to build computers. It was only in the late 1990s that we pivoted to services and software. By 2006, he made a conscious decision to not be the CEO. Since then, we have had successful leadership transitions, mostly from internal candidates.

From very early on, HCL was set up to be professional in nature at which point my father was playing the role of chief strategy officer and chairman of the board, but he wasn't the CEO. I think, in some ways certainly, he envisioned that I would join the board, which I did in 2013. Then I got appointed as chair in 2020. So, I had been on the board for seven years and

“We foster diversity and inclusion right from the top... We have phenomenal senior tenured women as well who I was able to attract... I am hoping that this DNA trickles down the organisation”

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had seen lots of transitions in the company. [My father] retired in 2020. He is also a very unique founder as most founders retire but don't leave. He retired and left the board, too. The HCL DNA is such: there are many leaders, but we are the sum of the parts.

Q: What has been your biggest learning from growing HCLTech?

A: I don't come from an engineering background, whereas HCLTech is the third-largest technology company in the country. So, working with people of diverse backgrounds and bringing your strength to the table.

Q: What is HCLTech doing to keep up with AI? You earlier said that AI will not replace workers. Do you still hold that view now?